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AI Receptionist Buyer's Checklist

What to ask, what to watch for, and a 10-minute test call to run before you pay for an AI phone answering service.

1. Questions to ask before you sign up

- ☐ **How is pricing counted?** Per minute, per call, or a flat monthly fee? What happens when I go over?
- ☐ **Does it book jobs directly** into my calendar or field service app (Jobber, Housecall Pro, ServiceTitan, Google Calendar), or does it only take messages?
- ☐ **Can it transfer a live call** to me or my on-call tech, and can I set rules (emergencies only, after hours, VIP customers)?
- ☐ **How do I get call summaries?** Text, email, app? How fast after the call?
- ☐ **Can I hear recordings and read transcripts** of every call? How long are they kept?
- ☐ **Does it handle Spanish** (or other languages your customers speak)?
- ☐ **Can I keep my existing number** using call forwarding, or do I need a new one?
- ☐ **Is there a free trial** with real calls, and is there a contract or can I cancel monthly?
- ☐ **Who do I call when it breaks?** Is there human support, and what hours?
- ☐ **Healthcare or legal?** Ask whether they will sign a BAA (HIPAA) or how they handle confidential client info.

2. Red flags

- ⚠ No way to listen to sample calls or try it on your own phone before paying.
- ⚠ Pricing that's only available "on a demo call" for a small business plan.
- ⚠ Annual contract required up front, or a large setup fee before you've tested it.
- ⚠ It can't say "I don't know." It makes up prices, availability, or policies instead of taking a message.
- ⚠ Spam and robocalls count against your minutes with no filtering.
- ⚠ You can't edit what it says (services, service area, hours) yourself.
- ⚠ Summaries arrive late or miss the caller's phone number and address.

3. The 10-minute test call script

Call it yourself (or have a friend call) from a cell phone. Score each step pass/fail.

1. **Normal booking:** "Hi, my water heater is leaking. Can someone come out tomorrow morning?" Did it get name, address, phone, and the problem, and offer a real time slot?
2. **Price question:** "How much do you charge for that?" It should give your approved answer (or a range or trip fee), not invent a number.
3. **Emergency:** "There's water all over my basement right now." Did it treat it as urgent and transfer or alert you?
4. **Off-script:** "Do you also do roofing?" (something you don't do). It should say no politely, not book it.
5. **Interruptions:** Talk over it, change your mind about the time, spell a hard last name. Does it keep up?
6. **Background noise:** Call from your truck or a noisy room.
7. **Ask for a human:** "Can I talk to a real person?" Does it follow your transfer rules?
8. **Hang up mid-call:** Do you still get a summary with the caller's number?
9. **Check the result:** Look at the summary, transcript and calendar. Is everything correct?
10. **Repeat after hours** and on a weekend.

4. Pricing gotchas

- ☐ Per-minute plans add up fast: 300 calls × 3 minutes = 900 minutes. Estimate your real call volume from your phone bill first.
- ☐ Check whether spam calls, voicemails, and transfers count as billed minutes.
- ☐ Look for overage rates, extra charges per phone number, and add-ons for bilingual answering, integrations or appointment booking.
- ☐ "Starting at" prices often leave out the booking or integration features you actually want.
- ☐ Compare against what a missed call costs you: if one booked job is worth $300+, a $100–$300/mo service only needs to catch one or two extra jobs.

5. Setup checklist

- ☐ Write down your services, service area (ZIP codes or towns), hours, and trip or diagnostic fee.
- ☐ Decide what counts as an emergency and who gets the transfer.
- ☐ List your top 10 customer questions and the exact answers you want given.
- ☐ Connect your calendar or field service app and block off time it shouldn't book.
- ☐ Set up call forwarding: always, after hours only, or when you don't pick up after X rings.
- ☐ Run the 10-minute test above before you turn it on for real customers.
- ☐ For the first two weeks, read every summary and fix wrong answers right away.

- [ ] After 30 days, count the jobs it booked vs. what you paid.

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